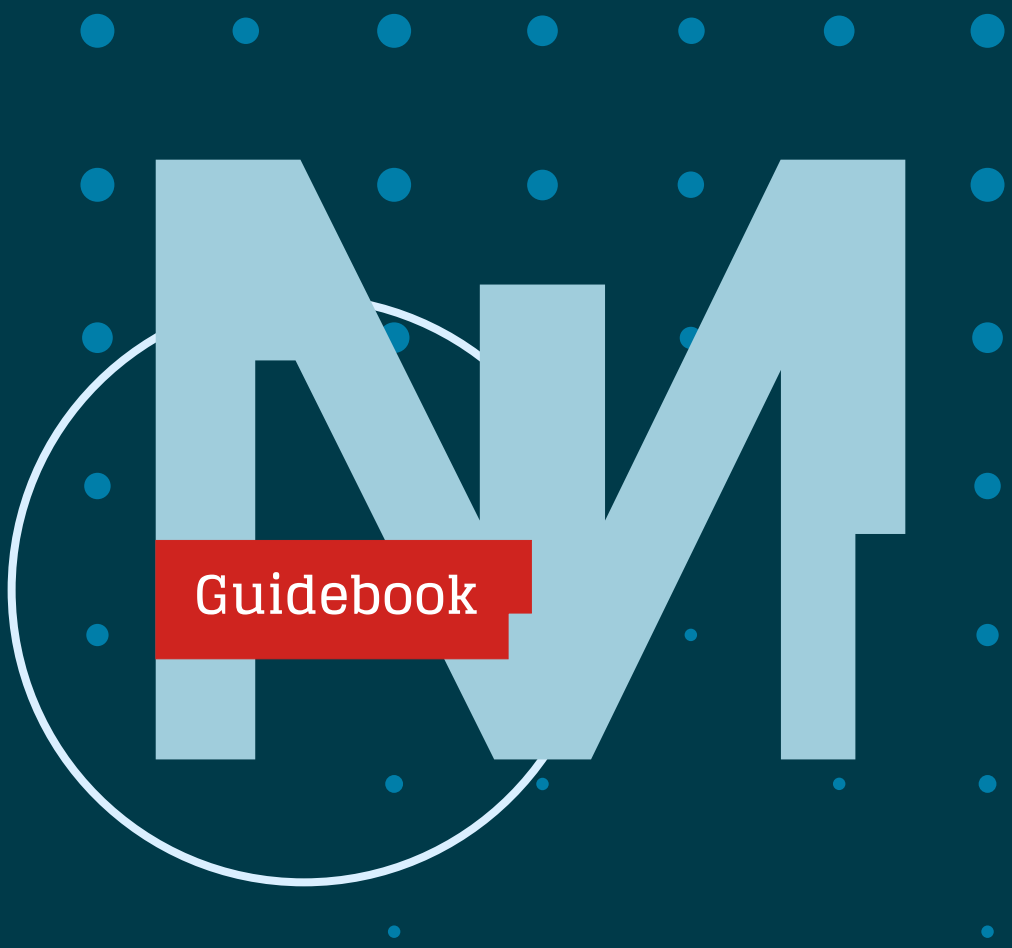
Making Qualitative Data Reusable



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Attribution

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1. About this guidebook

This guidebook offers an overview of the challenges involved in making qualitative data reusable and provides practical guidance on how to enhance reusability at each stage of the research data life cycle.

This guide was created by DANS, the Dutch national centre of expertise and repository for research data, and incorporates feedback from the community gathered through an open review process[1].

It has been created to support researchers and data stewards working with qualitative data and help them to make that data reusable.

We begin with a brief introduction to qualitative data and the unique challenges of making qualitative data available for reuse. We then outline the research process, providing advice on how to address reusability at each step. We cover topics such as planning a study, gathering informed consent, preregistration of research, the use of open tools for analysis, and options for de-identification of data. We also provide an overview of archiving and publishing options for (parts of) qualitative data. The guide includes decision trees that researchers and data stewards can use to assess the most suitable type of access for their projects, as well as examples of published datasets that are available for reuse.

While the guide may also be relevant to a broader audience, its primary focus is on the Dutch research community, particularly within the domain of social sciences, working with qualitative data. This guide also draws on findings from a small survey among Dutch data stewards (Verburg et al., 2023). The most recent update includes feedback gathered through presentations of the guide (e.g. Braukmann & Verburg, 2024) and an open consultation.

We hope that this guide will serve as a starting point for further discussions and improved guidance on making qualitative data reusable.

1 The initial version of this guide was created in the context of the NWO-funded project "Case-study Research and Data Reuse" (CaRe & DaRe), which focused on increasing and better facilitating the reuse of qualitative data in science.

2. Introduction

Qualitative data refer to information that is not gathered in numerical form, but rather describe qualities or characteristics. Data are expressed in natural language and often in textual or visual form. Collection methods, for instance, include photography, audio recordings, video, interviews, diary accounts, or other unstructured observations (CESSDA, 2022).

Qualitative data can be quite heterogeneous and take various forms. The types of qualitative data most often encountered by respondents to the Dutch data steward survey were interviews, video and audio recordings, transcripts, fieldnotes, focus groups, and observations (Verburg et al., 2023).

This type of data often contains personal and/or sensitive information. Personal information is defined as any information relating to an identified or identifiable natural person. Sensitive data include information that could cause harm to individuals, communities, public or private organisations, plants, and animals if disclosed[2]. Sensitive data can include sensitive personal information (such as sexual orientation, religious beliefs, or health data), as well as other types of information like business strategies or financial data.

As noted by Campbell and colleagues (2023), qualitative methods are used to study groups that are marginalised, part of a minority or have experiences of some trauma. Such data, therefore, require extra care. If not sufficiently de-identified, data sharing may pose significant risks to participants who have contributed their experiences.

The importance of making qualitative data reusable

The open science and FAIR (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, and Reusable) data movements advocate for research data to be well-documented and made available for reuse by others (Wilkinson et al., 2016). A widely supported principle is that data should be made “as open as possible, as closed as necessary”, allowing for reuse while protecting personal data, sensitive information, and intellectual property rights where appropriate (Landi et al., 2020).

2 Following the definition of the Research Data Alliance (RDA) Interest Group on Sensitive Data.

In alignment with these movements, many research funders, including the Dutch Research Council (NWO), now require data to be open. Researchers are increasingly expected to describe their data storage and archiving plans as part of a Data Management Plan (DMP, see NWO information page).

Making data available for reuse facilitates further research and reduces the cost of data collection. Data availability enhances the visibility of existing studies (e.g. Colavizza et al., 2020; Piwowar et al., 2007) and supports verification of research, thereby increasing the transparency of the scientific process (Munafò et al., 2017).

Collecting qualitative data is often time- and resource-intensive, which highlights the importance of reusing existing data wherever possible. Reuse also reduces the burden on participants in qualitative studies, who might otherwise be approached by multiple researchers for similar purposes. In addition, the richness of qualitative data makes it possible to address a wide range of research questions when shared for reuse.

The challenges in making qualitative data reusable

Compared to quantitative data, sharing qualitative data is often more complex and sometimes not feasible. A key challenge is to de-identify qualitative data without losing so much information that the data become unusable. Sharing identifiable data, however, may prove challenging or even unfeasible due to legal constraints (e.g. GDPR, copyright), the sensitive nature of the data (e.g. business information), or the potential risks to individuals (Campbell et al., 2023).

Another difficulty is that documentation and metadata cannot always capture all the contextual information needed to interpret qualitative data. Appropriate interpretation is further complicated by the variety and richness of such data, which are strongly shaped by the interaction between researcher and participants. This creates a fundamental distinction from quantitative data — a difference that must be taken into account when reusing data.

Despite growing recognition of these issues, practical guidance on qualitative data sharing remains limited (Verburg et al., 2023). Although recent scholarship has begun to address Research Data Management (RDM) and data sharing in qualitative research (e.g. Campbell et al., 2023; Chauvette et al., 2019; Corti, 2019), these aspects are still underrepresented in developments in open science and FAIR data.

Qualitative data cannot always be made available for reuse, but researchers should critically assess their projects and processes to maximise reusability wherever possible. In some cases, de-identified data can be shared openly; in others, access may need to be restricted, or the data offered only through alternative analysis processes. Even when the data themselves cannot be shared, researchers should still document and share information about the study under the principle of Open Methods.

Treating open science as a 'buffet' of options (Field, 2021) — rather than a single model applied uniformly — provides a more flexible way of working with qualitative data and supports decisions on how to maximise reusability. This guidebook sets out different pathways for making qualitative data reusable and the key considerations involved in evaluating these options.

CARE for qualitative data

The well-known FAIR principles state that data should be Findable, Accessible, Interoperable and Reusable (Wilkinson et al., 2016). Building on this, the CARE principles for Indigenous Data Governance were developed in 2017 by the International Indigenous Data Sovereignty Interest Group within the Research Data Alliance (RDA) (Carroll et al., 2020). CARE stands for Collective Benefit, Authority to Control, Responsibility, and Ethics, and each principle is supported by a set of sub-principles (Carroll et al., 2020).

The CARE principles were created in response to limited engagement with Indigenous Peoples' rights and interests in the push towards open data and open science. The Global Indigenous Data Alliance (GIDA) notes that FAIR, while valuable, primarily addresses the technical properties of data and overlooks power imbalances, historical injustices, and the rights of data communities. CARE strengthens the ethical governance of Indigenous data: data relating to Indigenous peoples and their interests (see this publication on CARE: Indigenous rights and open data).

Although the CARE principles were originally developed for Indigenous data, they are also relevant in other contexts where research participants may hold moral or cultural rights in the data they provide (see, for example, this post about CARE principles in linguistics).

Because qualitative data often includes personal information and may address sensitive topics or vulnerable groups, the CARE principles provide a valuable ethical framework. As highlighted in post on the Australian Text Analytics Platform (ATAP), respecting moral rights means recognising participants' authority over how their data is used, ensuring that they benefit from data sharing where possible, and conducting research in a transparent and ethical way.

CARE principles

Collective benefit

Data ecosystems shall be designed and function in ways that enable Indigenous peoples to derive benefit from the data.

Authority to control

Indigenous peoples' rights and interests in Indigenous data must be recognised and their authority to control such data be empowered.

Responsibility

Those working with Indigenous data have a responsibility to share how those data are used to support Indigenous peoples' self-determination and collective benefit.

Ethics

Indigenous peoples' rights and wellbeing should be the primary concern at all stages of the data life cycle and across the data ecosystem.

3. Planning your project

Reusability of qualitative data begins with careful planning. Ideally, it is addressed already at the stage of study design. Early choices in the research process can have a decisive impact on whether data can be reused, and under what conditions.

Funders increasingly require researchers to submit a Data Management Plan (DMP). Such plans help you anticipate and document decisions related to data collection, storage, documentation, and sharing. Although most DMP templates are designed for quantitative data, you are encouraged to interpret and adapt them to fit the specific characteristics of your projects.

Additional support is available from resources such as the CESSDA Data Management Expert Guide, which provides detailed planning guidance and a checklist with relevant questions. The Qualitative Data Repository also offers a DMP checklist.

At this stage, questions to consider when assessing whether and how your data can be made reusable include:

Considering participants:

- How will participants view the reuse of their data?
- Does data sharing serve participants' interests?
- What benefits or risks could it create for them?
- What steps can I take to support participants' autonomy over their data?
- What can I do to ensure that data are shared for collective benefit?

Engaging collaborators:

- Which other parties are involved in this project?
- How do they view making the data reusable?
- Will they support efforts to improve reusability?
- Who owns the data?
- Who needs to be consulted before the data are made available for reuse?
- What steps can I take to ensure a permanent point of contact for the dataset, especially if access is restricted?

Collecting personal data:

- Will the data include personal information?
- Is collecting this data in line with ethical and legal requirements (e.g. GDPR)?
- Can I de-identify personal data?
- How will de-identification affect the usefulness of the data?
- Is de-identification necessary for the study?
- Do I have valid consent to share personal data without de-identification?
- Can I minimise the amount of personal data collected?
- Can I separate personal information from content that can be shared openly?
- Do ethical restrictions prevent data sharing?
- Have I addressed data reusability explicitly in the informed consent forms?

Collecting sensitive data:

- Will my research involve the collection of sensitive data?
- Will participants be at risk if any of the information becomes available?
- Can I seperate sensitive information from content that can be shared openly?
- Does the level of sensitivity prevent data sharing altogether, or can sharing take place under specific conditions (e.g. restricted access, a secure environment)?
- What steps must I take to manage sensitive data in line with institutional policies (e.g. encryption)?

Using open formats and open tools:

- What formats will I use to collect and archive the data?
- Can I use open formats to ensure compatibility with different analysis programs?
- What tools will I use to process the data?
- What open-source tools are available that enable others to replicate my analysis?
- Do I need a Data Processing Agreement when using specific tools to handle personal or sensitive data?

Documenting the research process:

- What steps can I take to document the research process so that it is clear and transparent for others?

Preregistration of research

Preregistration is one initiative to improve research transparency. It involves specifying the research plan, including hypotheses and the intended analytical approach, before conducting the study (Nosek et al., 2018). Researchers can submit preregistrations to a registry such as the Open Science Framework, without further review. Some journals also publish registered reports, in which preregistered studies are reviewed by peers.

Although preregistration has traditionally been associated with quantitative research, its relevance and applicability to qualitative research remain under discussion. Critics argue that qualitative studies often do not test predefined hypotheses, rely on flexible research designs, and involve inherent subjectivity, which could make preregistration difficult and of limited value. Haven & van Grootel (2019) counter these concerns by arguing that such characteristics do not exclude the possibility of preregistration. Instead, they propose that preregistration can make the initial research framework and assumptions explicit, even if the interpretive process itself cannot be fully specified in advance.

Publishing these elements on an open platform invites community review and increases transparency. Haven & van Grootel further suggest that preregistration in qualitative research acts as a form of transparent documentation, offering value to the research community by clarifying the study's intended approach. They describe preregistration as a 'living document' that can be updated as the study progresses and new insights emerge. This evolving documentation allows others to follow how the analysis unfolds over time.

Haven and colleagues (2020) later explored which elements are essential in a preregistration template for qualitative studies. Based on their findings, they developed and published a template on the Open Science Framework.

You can use this template to describe a qualitative data project during the planning phase and submit it either to a public registry or to a journal as a registered report.

Preparing informed consent

Informed consent is a foundational principle in research ethics. It ensures that participants agree voluntarily to take part in a study, based on sufficient information about what participation entails. This includes information about how their data will be handled and what rights they have under relevant legal frameworks, such as the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR).

Article 7 of the GDPR sets out specific conditions for valid consent: it must be freely given, specific, informed, and unambiguous. Participants must also be able to withdraw their consent at any time.

More details about these legal requirements are available on the GDPR website.

Although the GDPR recognises other legal grounds for processing personal data, informed consent remains the most common basis in research involving human participants. Consent must be obtained before a participant or subject joins the research, without undue influence to give it. Participants should understand what the research is about and exactly what they are consenting to. Practical guidance on how to achieve this can be found in dedicated resources such as this guide.

Informed consent covers not only participation in the study itself but also what happens to the data afterwards. For example, the consent form may request permission to archive or share data with other researchers. If qualitative data are intended for reuse, researchers need to consider the ethical and legal implications in advance and include these clearly in the consent materials. Since consent often provides the legal basis for data reuse, this planning step is crucial.

The Qualitative Election Study of Britain publishes the documents it shares with participants on its website; these can serve as an example of a consent form used in an active study. Finally, most institutions are likely to have templates or guidance for informed consent practices. You should discuss these with the data stewards, who can advise on how to include data sharing in consent forms.

4. Organising and documenting

Organising and documenting your project and the data you collect at an early stage supports their future reusability.

During the organising and documenting phase, provide enough contextual information so that you and others can understand how the data are structured, and why, when, how, and by whom they were collected, processed, and presented. What counts as sufficient context will differ across projects and is not always easy to define in advance. Experience with existing datasets (see the examples later in this guidebook) shows that contextual information is often incomplete. Looking at your project from the perspective of someone unfamiliar with it can help identify what is needed to make your data clear and reusable.

The CESSDA Data Management Expert Guide offers good practices for file naming and folder structures, and provides examples for documenting qualitative data such as textual files, audiovisual material, and printed sources like periodicals or magazines. When naming files, avoid including personal data (such as interviewee names) in file or folder names. In general, minimise personal data and retain them only when relevant to your research question or necessary for understanding the dataset — for instance, when interviewing public figures in their professional roles.
Where possible, store personal or sensitive information separately from material that can be openly shared. This separation makes it easier to share parts of the dataset at a later stage. Encryption is advisable when handling sensitive or confidential qualitative data, and some institutions require the use of secure platforms. Local data stewards can advise on appropriate measures and policies. Planning for these distinctions early in the project will greatly simplify later steps such as archiving and publication.

A useful resource specifically designed for qualitative research is the Reproducible Open Coding Kit (ROCK). ROCK provides an open standard for qualitative data analysis that is both human- and machine-readable, with a focus on transparency, reproducibility, and open science. The ROCK website offers detailed guidance on managing projects, organising files, documenting data, and conducting coding and analysis using a defined structure. ROCK is based the open-source software R and can be run locally, making it accessible for a wide range of research projects.

5. Processing your data

Processing qualitative data requires choosing tools and methods that support reusability, reproducibility, and data security.

This guidebook does not provide a full manual for processing qualitative data, but it encourages researchers and data stewards to evaluate their choice of tools and to explore Free and Open-Source Software (FOSS) alternatives wherever possible.

Using FOSS tools enhances reproducibility, as other researchers can access and apply the same openly available resources. You are encouraged to follow community standards to improve interoperability and reusability within their field. At the same time, some widely used programs are not openly available and may create barriers for researchers outside that community.

The following section presents tools and suggestions currently known to the authors. You are invited to share additional FOSS tools for processing qualitative data[3] that could be included in future updates of this guide.

These tools have not been reviewed extensively with privacy officers. A future version of this guide will include more information on privacy and security aspects. The tools discussed here are not suitable for all types of data, so you need to assess their suitability for each study.

When working with personal data—particularly sensitive data—it is essential to consider whether a tool is appropriate. In most cases, qualitative data should be processed with tools run locally, ensuring that control is retained over where the data are stored and maintained.

3 Please send a message to info@dans.knaw.nl mentioning 'Contribution to guidebook Making Qualitative Data Reusable'.

Transcription and speech recognition

Several tools are available to support transcription and automatic speech recognition (ASR). Within CLARIAH, the Centre for Language and Speech Technology is developing a range of ASR tools, including one tool based on Whisper, for both Dutch and English.

Another Whisper-based tool, aTrain, has been developed by Graz University. Speech recognition tools are also available in Python (see, for example, this guide). In addition, oTranscribe provides a free, open-source web application for transcribing recorded interviews.

Widely used community-standard tools that are not open source but do offer transcription features include NVivo, QDA Miner, Otter.ai, Amberscript, and Transcription Online.

Annotation:

For the annotation of audio and video recordings, ELAN is a free tool developed by The Language Archive at the Max Planck Institute for Psycholinguistics. Taguette is another free and open-source tool designed for qualitative research, which enables users to import research materials and highlight and tag quotes.

Hypothes.is is an open annotation tool which, in partnership with the Qualitative Data Repository (QDR), co-developed the Annotation for Transparent Inquiry (ATI) to enhance transparency in the annotation of qualitative data.

Community-standard tools that are not open source but include annotation features are Atlas.ti, NVivo, and QDA Miner.

De-identification of personal data

When working with personal data, you must take additional steps, particularly if you plan to archive and share the data for reuse. Ethical considerations and legal regulations, such as the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), apply in these cases. You should consult your institution's privacy officer when handling personal or sensitive data.

As discussed in the section on informed consent, including data storage, archiving, and sharing in your consent materials provides a legal basis for processing personal data. Participants may also be asked to consent to the sharing of identifiable personal data, which is advisable when de-identification is difficult—for example, when working with video data or with material from well-known organisations or individuals who can be identified easily. Considering participants' perspectives in these decisions is important when deciding what type of data to share.

Later sections discuss how sharing qualitative data that has not been anonymised typically requires access restrictions. In some cases—where the data are sensitive and disclosure could cause harm to participants or organisations—sharing may not be possible at all. To protect participant privacy, de-identification is a key tool. Study participants can be de-identified by anonymising[4] or pseudonymising[5] the data. In qualitative research, however, de-identification is often challenging, even undesirable, as it can result in substantial information loss. Striking a balance between privacy and the interpretability of data is therefore essential. In some cases, data that cannot be fully de-identified may still be shared—for example, under restricted access conditions or through decentralised re-analysis, as outlined later.

The challenges of de-identifying qualitative data are widely recognised, and more guidance is becoming available. A recent paper by Campbell and colleagues (2023), Open Science Guidance for Qualitative Research: An Empirically Validated Approach for De-Identifying Sensitive Narrative Data, presents a methodological framework for remediating sensitive narrative data.

Useful guides on de-identifying qualitative data have also been developed by Erasmus University Rotterdam, UK Data Service, and the Qualitative Data Repository. Utrecht University has published an online Data Privacy Handbook with practical guidance on de-identification. A common recommendation across these guides is to develop a de-identification strategy at the start of your research.

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4 Data are anonymised if the removal of identifying characteristics is irreversible—meaning that participants cannot be re-identified, nor can the data be reverted to an identifiable state. Once fully anonymised, data are no longer considered personal data.

5 When a key is available that links de-identified data back to the original data, the data are pseudonymised. Under the GDPR, pseudonymised data are still considered personal data. Pseudonymisation may nevertheless help protect participant privacy.

The appropriateness of a particular tool must be assessed in the context of your research project. When handling personal and sensitive data, it is especially important to run tools locally, ensuring that control is retained over where the data are stored and maintained.

Tools for de-identifying qualitative data

Several tools support the de-identification of qualitative data, particularly textual data such as interview transcripts:

- anonymoUUS, a Python package developed at Utrecht University, enables pseudonymisation of folders and files in project documentation.
- The UK Data Service provides a text anonymisation helper tool for Microsoft Word, which highlights potentially disclosive terms so you can decide whether to amend them.
- Textwash is a free, open-source, automated multilingual text anonymisation tool that replaces disclosive information while preserving the semantic content of the data.
- Community-standard tools that are not open source but include anonymisation features are Atlas.ti and NVivo.

6. Archiving and publishing qualitative data

After you complete a research project, you should archive the data to ensure long-term preservation. Where possible, you can also publish data to make them available for reuse.

Given the value of qualitative data and the challenges of sharing and preserving it properly, you should deposit your data in a domain-specific trustworthy repository[6], such as the DANS Data Station Social Sciences and Humanities (SSH), which curates and preserves data for the long term (Mannheimer et al., 2018). Alternatively, your institution may recommend a suitable repository, for example DataverseNL. Your local data steward can provide further guidance.

Documentation and metadata

For qualitative data, documentation and metadata are essential to explain the research context, ensure understanding, and support potential reuse. When depositing data, provide as much metadata as possible so that the dataset is findable and its context clear. Although capturing every detail is challenging, many repositories offer guidance tailored to different disciplines and project types:

- DANS provides a metadata template for transcriptions of (audiovisual) interview data. The template is part of DANS guidance on preparing data for deposit, which also addresses metadata and documentation more broadly.
- The CESSDA Data Management Expert Guide includes a section on documentation and metadata, with guidance for both project-level and data-level documentation of qualitative data.
- The Finnish Social Science Data Archive, although it does not archive all kinds of qualitative data, offers practical guidance on organising and documenting background information, with useful examples.

Using a metadata standard ensures that data are described in a structured and interoperable way. In the social sciences, the Data Documentation Initiative Codebook (DDI 2.5) is most widely used. Although originally designed for quantitative data, it also applies to qualitative and mixed-methods research (Mannheimer et al., 2018).

6 A repository is considered trustworthy if it is certified by an internationally accepted standard that evaluated the processes of that repository. A well-established standard is the CoreTrustSeal certification.

Repositories may adopt other metadata standards tailored to their communities. For instance, the DANS Data Station SSH, as a member of CESSDA, follows the CESSDA Metadata Model (CMM).

The UK Data Service QualiBank uses DDI 2.5, the Qualitative Data Exchange schema (QuDEx), and the Text Encoding Initiative schema (TEI). The Qualitative Data Repository applies DDI 2.5 and the DataCite Metadata Kernel 3.1.

You do not have to master the technical details of these standards; curators at trustworthy repositories provide support in applying the appropriate metadata.

File formats

To facilitate reuse, you should archive data in file formats that are both accessible and sustainable. Open formats are generally preferred because they ensure long-term usability and do not require proprietary software to access, edit, or process the data.

In some cases, community standards rely on proprietary formats (e.g. because certain software dominates the field or because no open alternative exists). In such cases, depositing in that format is acceptable, but potential reusers from other communities may experience barriers. To reduce these barriers, always document the software and version have used.

Many repositories provide lists of preferred file formats that balance community standards with long-term preservation needs:

- DANS curates a list of preferred file formats for its Data Stations, including text, images, audio, video, and qualitative data analysis (CAQDAS) files, with explanations of the rationale.
- DANS and other repositories may also convert submitted data into preferred formats to ensure long-term accessibility.

Access categories

Most repositories distinguish between different access levels, such as open access and restricted access. For example, in the DANS Data Station SSH, open access allows anyone to download files, whereas restricted access requires permission. The next section outlines these access options in more detail and provides decision trees to help you identify the most suitable level for your project.

7. Decision trees

Deciding how and whether to make data accessible for reuse involves weighing several factors, and the best option is not always obvious. To support this process, this guidebook presents three decision trees that outline different ways to make qualitative data available in today's archival landscape. The decision trees are also available separately via Zenodo.

The following pages provide further context for the different reuse options, organised from the most open to the most restricted.

Each decision tree addresses a different aspect of your project:

- when your data are sensitive,
- when you need to comply with specific legal obligations,
- and when your dataset contains personal data.

You can work through each tree individually and combine the results to determine the most suitable access option for your data.

Even when data themselves cannot be shared, always publish your documentation and as much metadata as possible. This ensures that others are aware of your research and can understand its context.

Qualitative data reuse decision tree

As open as possible, as closed as necessary

A. Mitigating risks

Does your dataset contain data that could cause harm if disclosed?

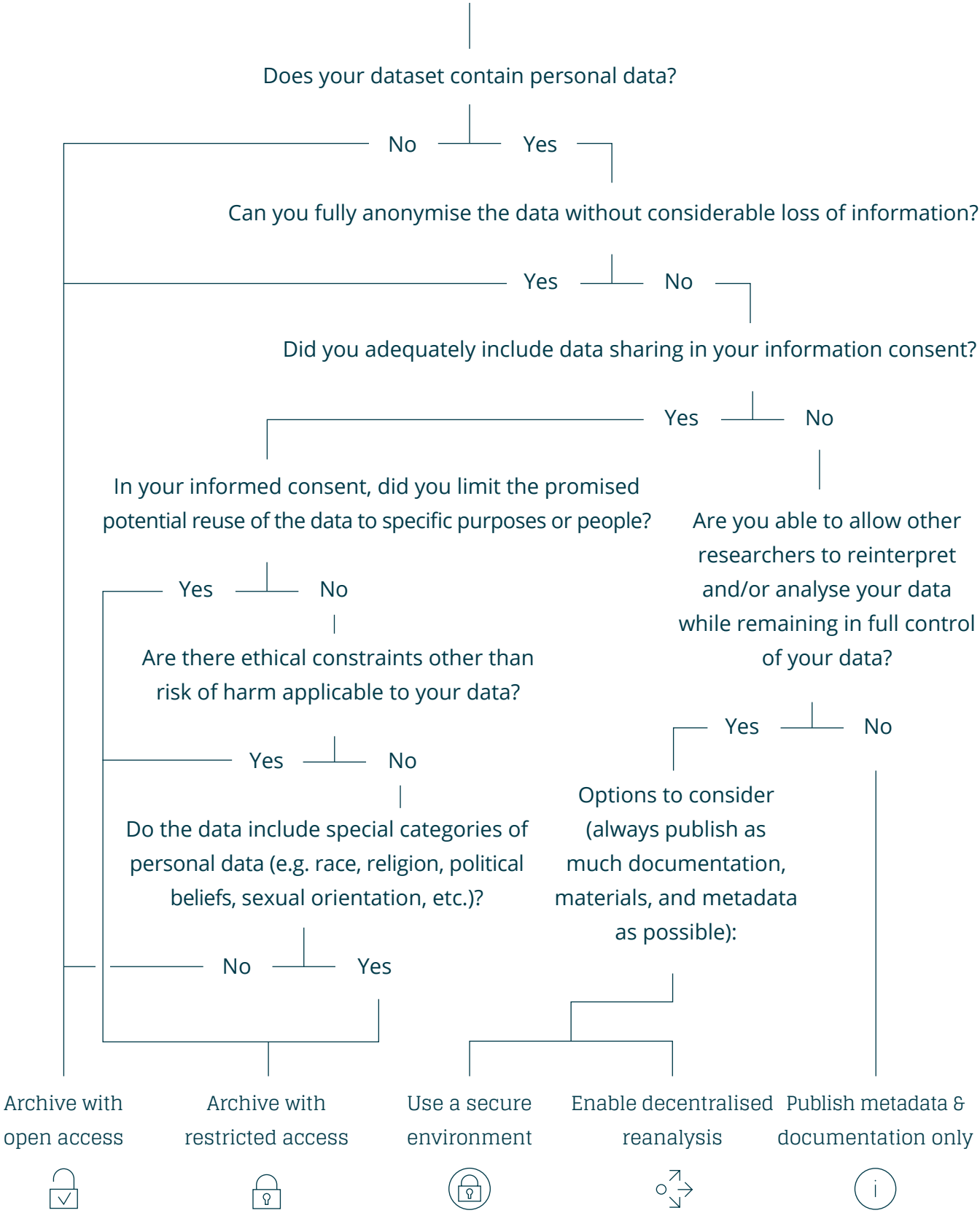
- No → Archive with open access
- Yes → Can you remove that data without considerable loss of information?
  - Yes → Archive with restricted access
  - No → Are you able to allow other researchers to reinterpret and/or analyse your data while remaining in full control of your data?
    - Yes → Options to consider (always publish as much documentation, materials, and metadata as possible):
      - Use a secure environment
      - Enable decentralised reanalysis
    - No → Publish metadata & documentation only

B. Complying with legal obligations

Are you legally restricted in sharing the data (e.g. copyright, external permissions, etc)?

- No → Archive with open access
- Yes → Are you able to allow other researchers to reinterpret and/or analyse your data while remaining in full control of your data?
  - Yes → Options to consider (always publish as much documentation, materials, and metadata as possible):
    - Archive with restricted access
    - Use a secure environment
    - Enable decentralised reanalysis
  - No → Publish metadata & documentation only

C. Protecting personal data



Archive with open access

If your dataset does not contain personal data and is not sensitive, you may consider archiving it with open access. Open access allows anyone to download the data freely, without the need to register. This applies both to human users who wish to reuse the data and to machine access.

When open access is possible, follow the principle of publishing 'as open as possible' by selecting the most permissive licence available. The CC0[7] licence is the most open, as the copyright holder waives all rights and places the data in the public domain. In practice, most open access research data are published under a Creative Commons (CC) licence that requires attribution. The CC-BY licence is the least restrictive of these and is the most widely used for open access datasets.

For qualitative data—particularly interview data—open access publication is usually not feasible. In such cases, restricted access is applied instead (see section below). If personal data are involved, the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) may also require restrictions. Fundamental discussions continue about whether CC licences are appropriate for interview data[8].

Nevertheless, assess whether parts of your data and documentation can be made openly available. Documentation and metadata can often be shared, and in some cases, anonymised parts of a dataset may also be suitable for open access. For example, fully anonymised transcripts are no longer considered personal data under the GDPR and may, in principle, be shared openly.

In all cases, carefully consider your participants. Inform them about your data publication plans as part of your preparations. For further information, see the sections on informed consent and de-identification in this guidebook.

7 If you would like more information about licences and which one to chose, you can find information in the guidance from DANS. [accessed May 7th 2025].

8 See the section "Can Creative Commons licenses be used alongside GDPR?" [accessed May 7th 2025].

Archive with restricted access

In many trustworthy digital repositories—such as the DANS Data Station SSH—you can set the access level for the files in your dataset. In the social sciences and humanities, repositories often provide the option of restricted access. Under restricted access, anyone interested in your data must submit a request for access, which you personally review. This arrangement allows you to share data only when specific conditions are met, for example restrictions from your informed consent procedure or requirements set by a funder, publisher, or another stakeholder.

For qualitative data, restricted access is far more common than open access because of the personal nature of the material and the challenges of anonymisation. Within the DANS Data Station SSH, a special licence applies to restricted access datasets, stipulating, among other things, that redistribution of the data is not permitted unless explicitly approved by the data owner.

When publishing data under restricted access, always specify the conditions under which requests will be granted. In addition, make sure that the contact details associated with your dataset remain accurate, so requests reliably reach you. Developing a Data Access Protocol can also help guide your decision-making. Such a protocol makes your reasoning transparent, ensures consistency in how you handle requests over time, and provides a fair basis for accepting or rejecting them. DANS offers a dedicated guide on publishing restricted access, which also includes a template Data Access Protocol.

Another form of restricted access is the embargo, where data only becomes available after a specified period of time. Embargoes are often used to align data availability with the release of a scientific publication. Once the embargo period ends, data may be made available under either open or restricted access. Some repositories also offer the option of a retention period, after which data become permanently inaccessible. This may be necessary for legal reasons. Both embargo and retention options are supported by the DANS Data Station SSH and by institutional repositories such as DataverseNL.

Even if your dataset is restricted, you should still make your project documentation and metadata openly available (see above). Doing so improves the visibility and findability of your research and helps others understand the context of your work.

Use a secure environment

When legal constraints apply or your data are highly sensitive, you may not be able to archive them in a repository. In such cases, you can still enable other researchers to analyse the data within a secure environment, where you retain full control over both the input and the results that are exported. In some situations, you may even require require a 'blind' analysis, where researchers do not have direct access to the original data but can run their algorithms to perform analyses.

The use of secure environments is a well-established practice for researchers working with microdata at Statistics Netherlands (CBS), which is highly sensitive. ODISSEI (Open Data Infrastructure for Social Science and Economic Innovations) and CLARIAH (Common Lab Research Infrastructure for the Arts and Humanities) have been collaborating with SURF on the development of SANE (Secure ANalysis Environment). SANE is built on ISO-27001 certified SURF services and has undergone rigorous penetration testing to guarantee a high level of security for data providers. Several pilot studies have already been conducted, and researchers can contact SURF to explore the use of SANE for their projects[9]. Using SANE or other secure environments requires financial and personal investment. Training may be needed both for researchers who access the environment and for data owners, who must prepare the data and may need to evaluate the results that researchers wish to export.

Even if the data themselves must be processed in a secure environment, you can often still share documentation and metadata about your project openly.

9 More information about SANE is available here.

Enable decentralised reanalysis

Decentralised reanalysis offers an innovative way to share qualitative data when other forms of sharing are not possible. This option was first piloted in the CaRe & DaRe project and is now being further developed in the OPEN-QUAL project. In this model, the data remain with the original creators. Potential reusers identify relevant datasets through the metadata and supporting documentation provided, and then submit an analysis protocol to the original researchers. The researchers conduct the requested analysis themselves and share only the results, not the underlying data. In return, they may receive co-authorship or another form of recognition for their contribution. This model enables cross-case studies and other forms of reuse, while reducing the risk of misinterpretation and decontextualisation, since the analysis is performed by those most familiar with the data.

It is important to note that this form of data reuse places an additional workload on the original researchers, which must be carefully weighed against potential benefits. Furthermore, adequate documentation and supporting information remain essential to ensure that reusers can correctly interpret the data, even if requests are received many years later.

The first pilot of decentralised reanalysis, presented during a Data Stewards Interest Group meeting, received broad enthusiasm from researchers and data stewards across multiple disciplines who would otherwise have been unable to facilitate reuse of their data. There is still considerable work to do in defining rules of engagement, protocols, and clearer guidance for practice—challenges that the OPEN-QUAL project (Innovating Methods for Open Science in Qualitative Management Research) seeks to address. For more information about this approach to qualitative data sharing, you can contact the project lead, prof. dr. ir. J.J. Berends[10].

Although the data themselves are not shared directly, you can still make project documentation and metadata openly available. This increases the visibility of your research, enables others to discover relevant datasets, and provides the foundation for meaningful reanalysis requests.

10 For contact on decentralised re-analysis approach, contact j.j.berends@vu.nl

Publish metadata and documentation only

If none of the available options make your data reusable, you can still publish documentation, materials, and as much metadata as possible about your research. Doing so makes your work discoverable by others. Even without access to the data, researchers benefit from knowing that the study exists—for example, when conducting reviews or literature studies. Your materials and documentation may also be valuable for reuse in other projects, regardless of the data.

Keep in mind, however, that the DANS Data Stations, like many other repositories, generally do not accept metadata-only records. Their mission is to enable data reuse, and the FAIR principles emphasise that data and metadata should remain linked. Repositories also aim to avoid hosting metadata while the underlying data are stored elsewhere. Still, some repositories do accept metadata-only deposits, so always check the policy of your institutional repository.

As an alternative, you can publish your project's metadata and documentation through platforms such as the Open Science Framework or Zenodo, a domain-agnostic general-purpose repository.

8. Example datasets

For inspiration on how to put the guidance from this booklet into practice, you can explore examples of qualitative datasets deposited in the DANS Data Stations. These datasets are available under either open or restricted access conditions. Reviewing how other researchers have documented and shared their work can provide useful examples of effective practices and demonstrate how such datasets can be made meaningfully reusable.

Open access

Examples of qualitative datasets available at DANS with access category 'open access':

- C.A. Hanzon, 2019, "Leren van herhaald beroep in de JeugdzorgPlus", https://doi.org/10.17026/dans-xkd-48aj, DANS Data Station Social Sciences and Humanities, V1
- AM Damen, 2022, "Palliatief Landelijk Onderzoek Eerstelijns Geestelijke verzorging (PLOEG) deelproject 3: 'Integratie GV eerste lijn vanuit 3 multidisciplinaire praktijken'", https://doi.org/10.17026/dans-xat-kj3c, DANS Data Station Life Sciences, V2, UNF:6:pg98gxovm7ySdXuitFYwYg== [fileUNF]
- M.D. Ducimetière; A.S. Soulioti, 2020, "Interview Eva Gonggrijp on Grenzeloze Inhoud", https://doi.org/10.17026/dans-zb9-cufs, DANS Data Station Social Sciences and Humanities, V2

Restricted access

Examples of qualitative datasets available at DANS with access category 'restricted access', where users must request permission from the data owner to use the data:

- C.J.M. Hofhuizen, 2022, "Zorgen en zwaaien: longitudinale studie naar de gevolgen van restrictieve maatregelen vanwege COVID-19 voor naasten van mensen met een verstandelijke beperking en hun behoefte aan ondersteuning", https://doi.org/10.17026/dans-xsr-tp2v, DANS Data Station Social Sciences and Humanities, V2
- A.A.L. van der Hulst, 2015, "Wegbereiders, Roma en Sinti in Nederland en Tsjechië over het profijt van onderwijs, 1950-2020 Interview 05", https://doi.org/10.17026/dans-zck-rtjr, DANS Data Station Social Sciences and Humanities, V2
- M.D. Ducimetière; M.V. Voogd; S. Stigter, 2020, "Interview Monique Laros on Roel QoQo and Grenzeloze Inhoud", https://doi.org/10.17026/dans-zv7-4ycu, DANS Data Station Social Sciences and Humanities, V2

Mixed: open and restricted access

Examples of datasets available at DANS where some files are openly available and others under restricted access. Note how openly available documentation and Data Access Protocols can be very helpful when assessing a dataset for reuse:

- Josephine Kymmell, 2025, "Interview met Henk Trumpie over Atelier Struktuur 68, Den Haag, 14 Januari 2025", https://doi.org/10.17026/SS/EZYTCU, DANS Data Station Social Sciences and Humanities, V2
- Stigter, Sanneke; Hatem, Amr; Mavroudis, Orestis, 2024, "Interview: My Bundgaard on Robert Rauschenberg's Mud Muse", https://doi.org/10.17026/SS/8RLLMN, DANS Data Station Social Sciences and Humanities, V1
- L.I.M. Lenferink; J. Pociūnaitė-Ott, 2025, "Grief in Daily life Archive (Grief-ID Archive)", https://doi.org/10.17026/SS/LNFAXI, DANS Data Station Social Sciences and Humanities, V2, UNF:6:lwOlVLKAoyhfY5H5PPiygw== [fileUNF][11]

11 This dataset is not a qualitative dataset but contains a very extensive Data Access Protocol which is a good example how detailed information can be helpful to judge whether access would be provided.

9. Final thoughts

This guide aims to support researchers and data stewards in exploring practical and responsible ways of sharing and reusing qualitative data throughout the different phases of a project. Although qualitative data may not always align neatly with existing data management and sharing policies, there are still valuable ways to make all or parts of such datasets reusable, even when they are complex.

Because of the unique way in which qualitative data are collected, and the wide range of disciplines that may benefit from them, making these data more accessible for reuse can have a significant impact. Their value may extend far beyond the communities originally envisaged by the researchers. The principle 'as open as possible, as closed as necessary' is therefore highly relevant to qualitative data. At the same time, any decision to share must carefully weigh the sensitivity of the data and the potential risks for participants.

This guide represents an overview of resources and considerations aimed at stimulating the discussion around the reuse of qualitative data. If you would like to share additional information, tools, or resources relevant to this topic, we warmly invite you to contact us[12] so that they may be included in a future edition of this guide.

12 Please send a message to info@dans.knaw.nl mentioning 'Contribution to guidebook qualitative data'.

10. Additional resources

In addition to the guidance, tools and tips presented in this guidebook, several longer-form resources are available for those who wish to deepen their knowledge of research data management in the context of qualitative data.

Resources for qualitative data:

- UK Data Service – offers webinar recordings and presentation materials on qualitative data.
- The Qualitative Data Repository – provides an overview of conferences, workshops, and training related to qualitative data.
- Managing Qualitative Social Science Data – an online course created by the Social Science Research Council and the Qualitative Data Repository.
- Circular Research Data Coursebook on Qualitative FAIR data – course materials of a workshop developed at Maastricht University.

Resources for personal or sensitive data:

- Research Data Netherlands – offers a GDPR course for data supporters, which can be followed formally or accessed freely online.
- The Data Privacy Handbook (Utrecht University) – provides knowledge, tools, and use cases for working with personal data.
- EOSC-Future 'ask me anything' session – features a recorded webinar that addresses common challenges and questions related to sensitive data.
- CARE Principles – visit this site for more information about the CARE principles.

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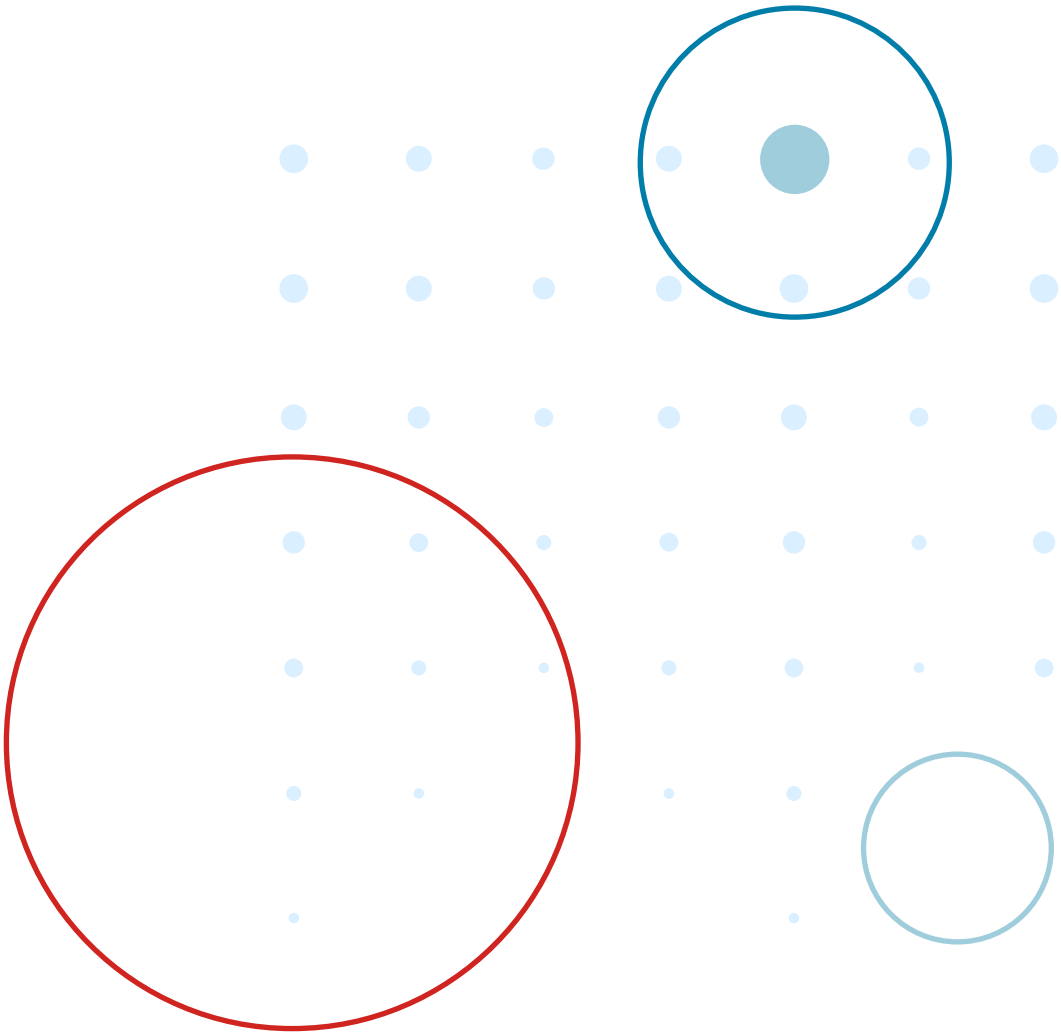

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